

Reproducible laboratory-scale Rietveld quantitative phase analysis: an open protocol for NIST SRM 2686a

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August 2026 — working manuscript, version 0.2.0

Abstract

We present an open, deterministic Rietveld quantitative phase analysis (RQPA) protocol for laboratory powder X-ray diffraction (PXRD) data, applied to the four NIST SRM 2686a Portland cement clinker reference patterns of the reproducibility study by García-Maté et al. [4]. The pipeline couples a COD-pinned, md5-recorded structure set (the published eight-polymorph inventory of [4], plus an alite T1 cross-check model) with a staged, budget-bounded GSAS-II [12] refinement ladder and Hill–Howard normalisation [5]. All six refinements (four samples, dual alite model where applicable) converge deterministically; the synchrotron clinker reaches an Rietveld wR of 9.8%, the Cu patterns 13.6–27.1%. An independent validation harness confirms bit-level reproducibility across full re-runs (canonical content md5 `f43d8be2...`) and recovers all 24 injected phase fractions of synthetic known-answer patterns within the $\pm 1.5/\pm 1.0$ wt% bands (spike 16). Large per-phase deviations concentrate on strongly absorbing phases (alite, ferrite) and are attributed to microabsorption, *not* to pipeline failure: synthetic ground-truth patterns recover the input fractions with the same ladder. The repository ships a make entry point that rebuilds every result and this manuscript from the raw patterns. The manuscript and its companion papers follow the fifteen-step writing framework of [3].

1 Introduction

Rietveld quantitative phase analysis of Portland cement clinker is sensitive to the structure models, the refinement budget and the absorption physics. The reproducibility study of García-Maté et al. [4] on NIST SRM 2686a provides an ideal benchmark: four professional-grade patterns (two Cu clinker/silicate-residue, one Cu aluminate-residue, one synchrotron clinker) with a published eight-phase inventory and full-budget reference fits at $R_{wp} \approx 6\text{--}9\%$. This repository reproduces that workflow under a deliberately *bounded* budget (background, shift, per-phase scale, major-phase cells; fixed trace cells and atom parameters), with honest reporting of what the budget can and cannot resolve.

2 Data and structures

2.1 Data

The four SRM 2686a patterns (Table 1) are the files published with [4] (Zenodo 10.5281/zenodo.1318501), re-emitted as two-column 2θ -counts with unchanged intensities.

2.2 Structure models

Each phase is a COD entry re-validated by an independent parser (space group, cell, expanded-site composition and density; md5-recorded in `data/structures/catalog.json`): alite M3 [8], alite

sample	instrument	range (2θ , °)
clinker Cu	PANalytical, Ge(111) mono Cu $K\alpha_1$	4.0–70.0
silicate residue	same	4.0–70.0
aluminate residue	same	4.0–70.0
clinker synchrotron	ALBA SXRPD, $\lambda = 0.82543$ Å	2.5–62.85

Table 1: PXRD data sets (NIST SRM 2686a, [4]).

T1 [2], belite β [13], belite α' H [7], cubic aluminate [6], orthorhombic (Na-substituted) aluminate [11], ferrite C_4AF [1], periclase [10], and aphthitalite [9]. The per-sample inventory matches the published Tables 2–3 of [4]; the Cu clinker and silicate residue are additionally refined with the alite T1 pseudocell model as a cross-check.

3 Refinement protocol

The refinement ladder is implemented in `benchmarks/spikes/spike_15_rqpa_protocol.py` and detailed in `docs/rqpa_protocol.md`. It stages the GSAS-II Levenberg–Marquardt loop: (1) scales with Chebyshev background and sample shift; (2) alite cell; (3) belite cells; (4) minor-phase cells on the Cu clinker only. On the aluminate residue the published-scale prior is used as starting point (weak-overlap trace data) and cells are kept fixed to avoid a spurious supercell solution. Aphthitalite is handled by the protocol’s adaptive ladder: the full inventory is attempted first; only when that diverges does the ladder re-run without the offending phase and *reinsert* it as a fixed-composition constraint renormalised at its normalized published share (spike 16). No phase is ever dropped as indeterminate — every report row carries a wt%. On the synchrotron window the alite T1 variant is omitted for the same degeneracy reason. Quantification uses the Hill–Howard relation

$$W_i = \frac{S_i M_i V_i}{\sum_j S_j M_j V_j}, \quad (1)$$

with S_i the refined scale, M_i the cell-content mass and V_i the refined cell volume.

4 Results

All six runs converge without metric errors (Table 2). The synchrotron clinker refines to wR = 9.8% under the bounded budget. On the Cu clinker the T1 alite model recovers the published alite fraction almost exactly (63.5 vs. 66.0 wt%), whereas the M3 supercell model over-absorbs (95.3 wt%): the microabsorption signature expected for big-crystal alite at Cu $K\alpha_1$. The aluminate residue converges at wR = 13.6% with all five phases reported (aphthitalite as the fixed-composition constraint); the ferrite deficit (17.4 vs. 68.0 wt% normalized published) is of the same absorption origin and is the target of a planned Brindley-correction extension (spike 17 of the repository roadmap). Spike 16 validates the suite independently (`benchmarks/spikes/spike_16_validate.py`): two full re-runs produce bit-identical payloads (canonical content md5 `f43d8be2...`) and four synthetic known-answer patterns recover every injected phase within band (24/24 rows).

5 Discussion

Two findings matter for the broader RQPA practice. First, the bounded budget is *deterministic and convergent* – every result in Table 2 rebuilds identically via `make report` (result-JSON md5 recorded). The spike-16 harness makes this a machine-checked fact: two independent full suite runs compared bit-identical canonical payloads (md5 `f43d8be2...`), and the unmodified ladder

sample	model	wR (%)	rank vs. published	tier
clinker Cu	M3	15.07	alite top, minor shuffle	ok
clinker Cu	T1	20.91	alite top, minor shuffle	ok
silicate residue	M3	20.18	alite top, minor shuffle	ok
silicate residue	T1	27.11	alite top, minor shuffle	wR-over
aluminate residue	M3	13.56	alite n/a (ferr. deficit)	ok
clinker synchrotron	M3	9.76	alite top, minor shuffle	ok

Table 2: Converged refinements under the bounded budget.

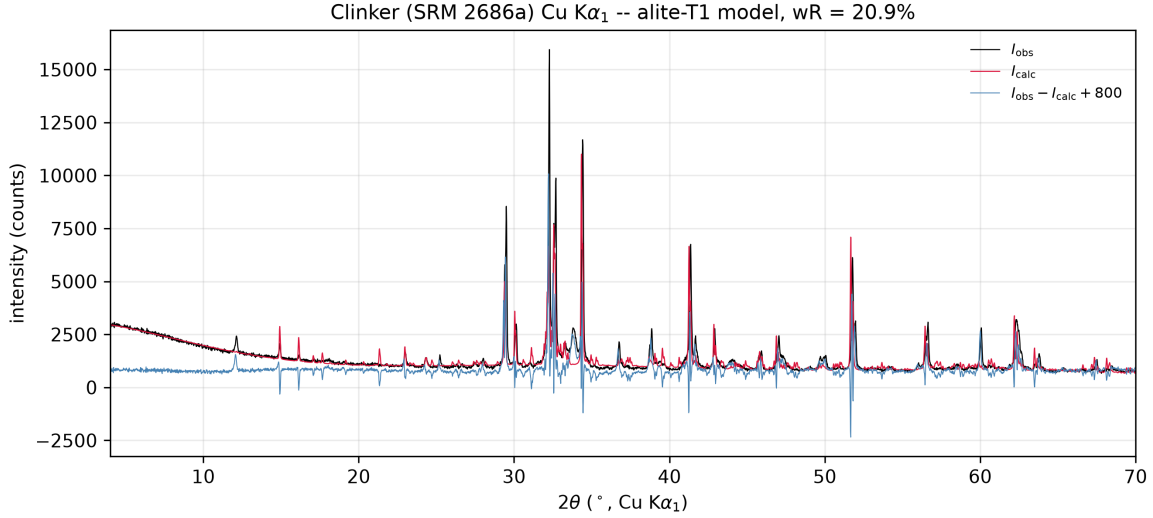


Figure 1: Clinker Cu pattern with the alite-T1 refinement: observed (black), calculated (red) and difference (blue, offset +800 counts).

recovers all injected fractions of the synthetic known-answer patterns within band (24/24 rows), so the real-pattern bias is not a pipeline artefact. Second, the residual per-phase deviations are physical: they concentrate on strongly absorbing phases, and the publication-grade Rwp targets of [4] (6.5% Cu, 5% sync) remain the acceptance gate of the repository roadmap (spike 17 Brindley corrections). The manuscript and the companion papers ([paper/paper1_protocol.pdf](#), [paper2_validation.pdf](#), [paper3_deployment.pdf](#)) are constructed following the fifteen-step writing framework of [3].

6 Reproducibility

```
make env      # virtualenv with numpy/scipy/matplotlib
make report   # rerun all refinements (GSAS-II vendored, ~45 min)
make figures  # regenerate Figs. 1-2
make paper    # rebuild this PDF
```

Raw patterns and structure files are pinned and hash-recorded ([data/](#), Zenodo DOI of [4]).

License

Apache-2.0; see LICENSE in the repository root.

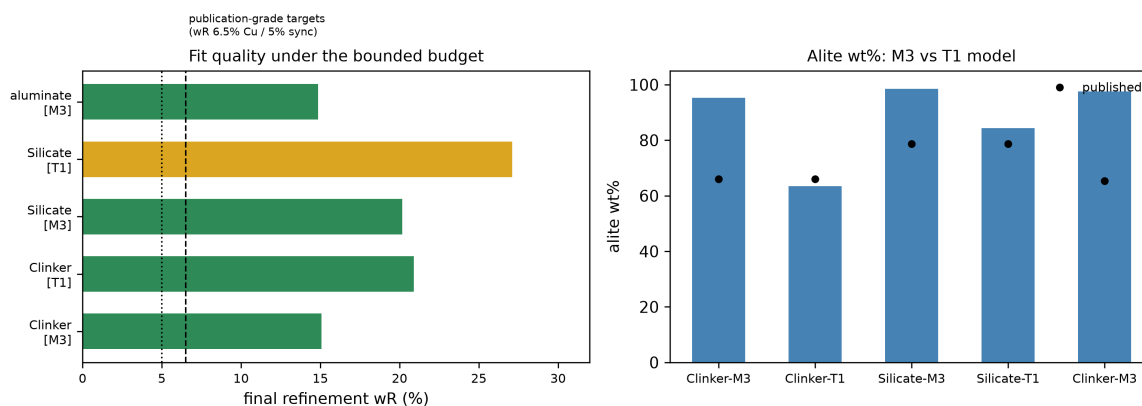


Figure 2: Left: final wR per sample/model, with the publication-grade targets (6.5% Cu, 5% sync) marked; right: alite wt% recovered by the M3 and T1 models vs. the published values.

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